



Flood Risk Supplementary Planning Document



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City of
Doncaster
Council

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1. Introduction

1.1. Purpose of the Document

- 1.1.1. This SPD has been prepared to clarify the expectations of the Council with regards to flood risk and planning applications. It supports Local Plan Policy 57: Flood Risk Management, and explains to developers and landowners how to apply local and national policy on managing flood risk and the approach that planning applications must take with regards to this.
- 1.1.2. For site specific drainage requirements, please see Section 7.3 of the Council's [Technical and Developer Requirements SPD](#).

2. Flood Risk in Doncaster

2.1. Background

- 2.1.1. The topography of Doncaster is predominantly flat (some of it below sea level) and relies heavily on an extensive system of man-made drainage channels, pumps and other control structures to drain effectively.
- 2.1.2. There are a number of large rivers, which flow through Doncaster: River Don, Dearne, Torne, Went and the Ea Beck, along with several other minor rivers. The Borough is split hydraulically between the River Don and Trent catchments, served by two Environment Agency areas (Yorkshire and East Midlands). The Borough is also split between three water authorities; Yorkshire, Severn Trent and Anglian (Anglian only serves a very small area).
- 2.1.3. The Council maintain Council owned watercourses, clear grilles of debris hotspots, advise on flood risk, design flood alleviation works, inspect and maintain Council owned pumping stations. Through the planning process, we mitigate flood risk due to the impact of development.
- 2.1.4. The Council has limited records regarding any flood incidents, which isn't to say they didn't occur, but the only recorded details the Council have are since the floods of June 2007, where 3286 properties were flooded, including 2275 of those suffering major (internal flooding to property) damage. There have been numerous flooding incidents prior to 2007, with the most notable being those of Autumn 2000 and Spring 1947. The implementation of the Flood and Water Management Act 2010 provided the legislation and impetus for local authorities to manage flood risk more effectively. The improved response to the flood event in July 2012, which saw the internal flooding of 49 properties, was much more co-ordinated.
- 2.1.5. Flooding in the winter of 2019-20 had a significant effect on a number of areas and was brought to national attention as a sizeable and escalating risk for many people and communities. 1869 households across the Borough were given support and advice in the early weeks after flooding, with 689 of these given "see and solve" help to follow up on specific issues.

3. Policy Basis

3.1. National Policy

- 3.1.1. The [NPPF](#) states that “inappropriate development in areas at risk of flooding should be avoided by directing development away from areas at highest risk. Where development is necessary in such areas, the development should be made safe for its lifetime without increasing flood risk elsewhere”.
- 3.1.2. To achieve this aim, the NPPF requires that all plans and development proposals apply a Sequential Test risk-based approach and, where necessary, an Exception Test. The Sequential Test is to steer development to areas with the lowest risk of flooding from any source. If it is not possible for development to be located in areas with a lower risk of flooding, then an Exception Test may be required which will depend on the potential vulnerability of the site and the development proposed. [Table 1 of the Planning Practice Guidance \(PPG\)](#) provides definitions of the Flood Zones, from low to high probability of river and sea flooding. [Annex 3 of the NPPF](#) sets out the flood risk vulnerability classification and [Table 2 of the PPG](#) sets out the flood risk vulnerability and Flood Zone ‘incompatibility’.
- 3.1.3. To pass the exception test it should be demonstrated that: a) the development would provide wider sustainability benefits to the community that outweigh the flood risk; and b) the development will be safe for its lifetime taking account of the vulnerability of its users, without increasing flood risk elsewhere, and, where possible will reduce flood risk overall.
- 3.1.4. As well as the sequential test and exception test, the NPPF states that applications should be supported by a site-specific flood risk assessment, explained in footnote 55. It also confirms that following a Sequential Test and, where necessary, Exception Test, development should only be allowed if the most vulnerable development is located in the areas of lowest flood risk and that it is flood resilient.
- 3.1.5. [Planning Practice Guidance](#) (PPG) has been published relating to flood risk and coastal change. This builds on the requirements set out in the NPPF and elaborates on the importance of undertaking Sequential Tests, Exception Tests and site-specific flood risk assessments. PPG also clarifies the roles of the Environment Agency (EA) and Lead Local Flood Authorities (LLFAs) in assessing planning applications.
- 3.1.6. Some minor developments and changes of use (explained in footnote 56 of the NPPF) should not be subject to the sequential test or exception test but should still meet the requirements for site-specific flood risk assessments as set out in footnote 55.

3.2. Local Policy

- 3.2.1. The [Doncaster Local Plan](#) sets out how the Council will ensure that it addresses and adapts to climate change, including changes likely to arise through increased flooding arising from more frequent incidents of extreme weather. The Council must follow a risk-based approach to the location of development to avoid flood risk where possible, and ensure the residual risks of flooding from artificial sources including canal networks to people and property are properly managed where development is necessary in areas at risk from flooding for wider sustainability benefits.

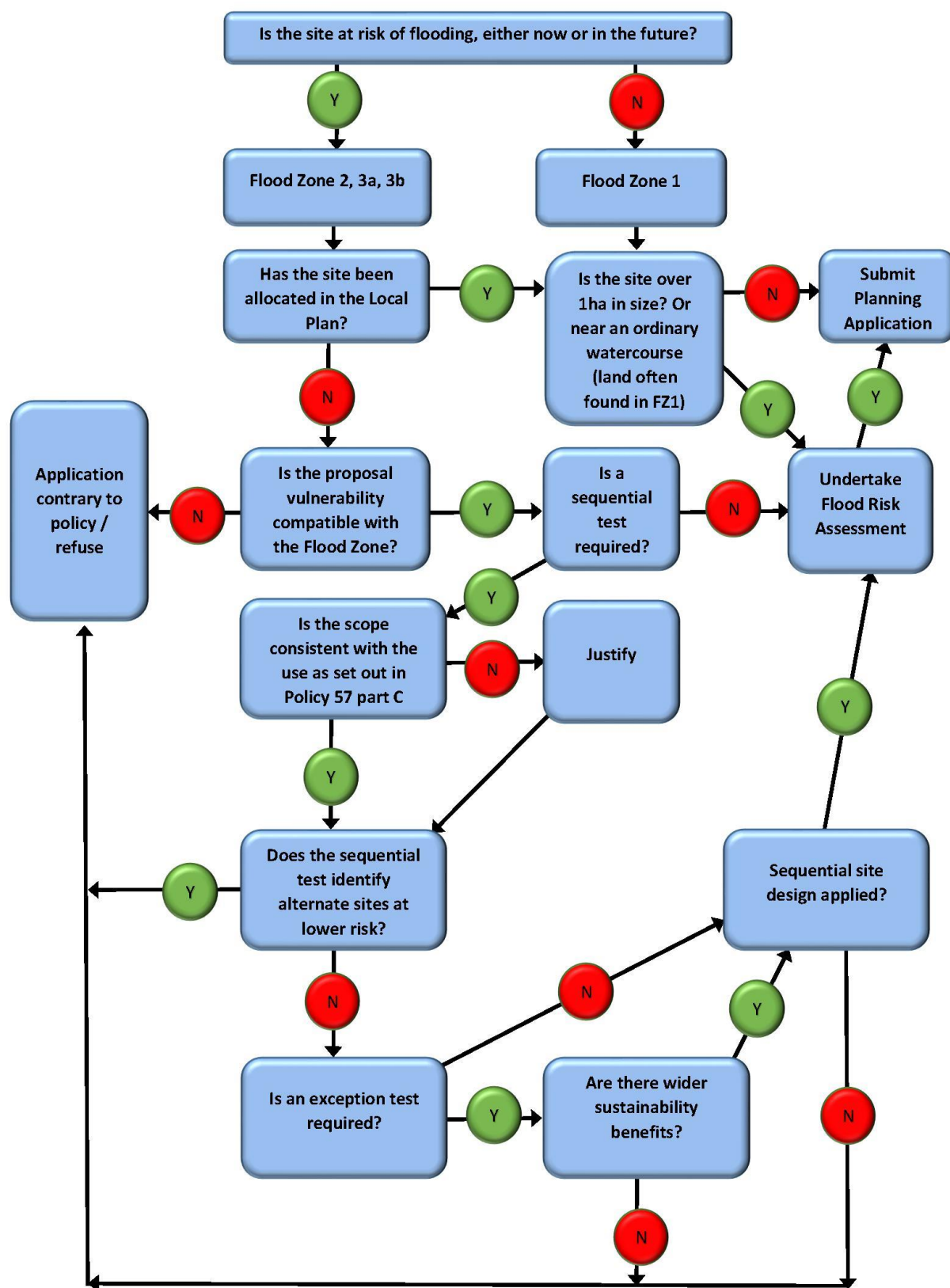
- 3.2.2. Local Plan Policy 57 relates to flood risk management and states that all development proposals will be considered against the [NPPF](#) including application of the Sequential Test (see [Section 6](#) below) and, if necessary, the Exception Test (see [Section 7](#) below).
- 3.2.3. No sites for 'more vulnerable' uses in Flood Zones 2 or 3, which did not already have planning permission, were allocated in the [Local Plan](#). A number of additional sites were allocated as 'Potential Development Sites' (see policies 3 and 5) which are generally sites that failed the Sequential Test at plan-making stage – so any future development proposals on these sites will still need to demonstrate a satisfactory pass of the Sequential and Exception Tests.
- 3.2.4. Policy 57 also clarifies the approach for all windfall developments in Flood Zones 2 and 3 and the areas of search for Sequential Tests for different types of development.
- 3.2.5. Supporting paragraph 14.7 to Policy 57 notes that applications for development on Local Plan allocations, which accord with the use, will be deemed to have passed the Sequential Test as long as no changes have arisen with respect to the understanding of flood risk since the Local Plan was adopted. Any proposals for 'more vulnerable' uses on employment and mixed use allocations will still need to pass a sequential test at planning application stage. Potential Development Sites have not passed a Sequential Test and any applications on such sites which fail a Sequential Test should normally be refused.

4. The Flood Risk Assessment Process for Planning Applications

4.1. Assessing Flood Risk

- 4.1.1. [Figure 1](#) below shows the process applications will have to go through prior to submission to justify themselves with regards to flood risk. Depending on the location of development, this could be up to a five stage process:
 - 1) Assessing the flood risk for the site ([Section 5](#));
 - 2) Undertaking a Flood Risk Sequential Test ([Section 6](#));
 - 3) Undertaking an Exception Test where necessary ([Section 7](#));
 - 4) Designing the site to account for flood risk ([Section 8](#));
 - 5) Undertaking a site specific flood risk assessment ([Section 9](#)).

Figure 1 : Assessing Flood Risk



5. Assessing the Flood Risk for a Site

5.1. Consideration of Risk and Sources of Information

5.1.1. Flood risk to development depends on two things:

- 1) [The Location of Development and its Risk of Flooding](#); and
- 2) [The Proposed Use and its Vulnerability to Flooding](#).

5.1.2. Both of these factors must be taken in to account and will determine what, if any, assessment(s) are required to be undertaken with regards to flood risk.

5.2. The Location of Development and its Risk of Flooding

5.2.1. To assess the flood risk to a site, applicants should consult both the EA [Flood Map for Planning](#) and the Doncaster [Strategic Flood Risk Assessment](#) (SFRA) Level 1. Applicants should bear in mind that flood risk information can and does change as new modelling is undertaken providing a better understanding of flood risk. Evidence, such as the SFRA, is a point in time and applicants must check all sources of information to make sure that they are referring to the latest available published data. The Local Plan's [Policies Map](#) also includes key flood risk information and the Council will endeavour to maintain and keep this up-to-date as and when changes occur.

5.2.2. The Flood Map for Planning assesses the risk of flooding from the sea and rivers; and categorises flood risk zones as follows, based on the likelihood of flooding in any given year:

Table 1: Flood Zones

Flood Zone	Flood Probability	Definition
Flood Zone 1	Low	1:1000 year chance of flooding (less than 0.1% chance in a year)
Flood Zone 2	Medium	Between a 1:1000 year chance and 1:100 year chance of river flooding (0.1% - 1% in a year); or between a 1:1000 and 1:200 chance of sea flooding (0.1% - 0.5% chance in a year)
Flood Zone 3a	High	Greater than 1:100 a year (1%) chance of river flooding in a year, or greater than 1:200 (0.5%) chance of sea flooding in a year.
Flood Zone 3b	Functional Flood Plain	Greater than 3.3% annual probability of flooding, with any existing flood risk management infrastructure operating effectively. Land that is designed to flood, even if it would only flood in more extreme events.

5.2.3. It should be noted that although the Flood Map for Planning does not differentiate Zone 3, local authorities can determine in consultation with the EA the extent of Flood Zone 3b (functional floodplain/water storage). This has been defined within the current [Doncaster SFRA](#) and the Local Plan's Policies Map also shows this for information purposes. Most development proposals in the functional flood plain should not be permitted with a handful of exceptions (Essential Infrastructure and Water Compatible uses may be supportable and subject to conditions as per the PPG).

- 5.2.4. Development within Flood Zone 1 and not at risk from other sources of flooding, such as surface water, will not require a flood risk Sequential Test or Exception test to be undertaken, although a site specific flood risk assessment may still be needed (see [Section 9](#) for details of when this is required).
- 5.2.5. When development falls within Flood Zones 2 or 3, or is at risk of flooding from other sources, such as surface water or groundwater flooding, the need for a Sequential Test depends on the type of development, if the site was not allocated for the proposed use in the Local Plan. If it was allocated in the Local Plan for the same use as is being proposed, then a Sequential Test will not be required so long as there have been no changes to the understanding of flood risk since the Plan was adopted – however, an exception test and/or a site specific flood risk assessment may still be required (please refer to [Sections 7 and 9](#)).
- 5.2.6. Should applicants wish to challenge the EA Flood Map for Planning, then this should be taken up directly with the EA as it is not the Council's data or designation. If such a challenge is successful, the Council will need written confirmation from the EA that the Flood Zone challenge has been accepted (this could be before the Flood Map for Planning is then subsequently updated) and what the revised Flood Zone/Probability will be in order to consider the development to be at a lower risk of flooding for the purposes of Local Plan Policy 57 and this SPD. Any challenges to the extent of the functional flood plain (Flood Zone 3b) should be taken up with Doncaster Council's Planning Policy & Environment Team in the first instance who will liaise with colleagues internally as the Lead Local Flood Authority. It should be noted that work required in support of any challenges will be at the expense of the applicant.

5.3. The Proposed Use and its Vulnerability to Flooding

- 5.3.1. Once the applicant has established the flood zone, they will then need to check that the proposal is compatible with the Flood Zone in accordance with the Vulnerability Classifications listed in the NPPF, Annex 3. Annex 3 provides a list of developments defined by their flood risk vulnerability. The PPG specifies certain vulnerability classifications that should not be permitted in certain Flood Zones.
- 5.3.2. Annex 3 should be read in conjunction with [Table 2 of PPG](#) on [Flood Risk and Coastal Change](#) regarding flood risk vulnerability and Flood Zone incompatibility (see [Table 2](#), below). This should state that certain vulnerability classifications should not be permitted.

Table 2: Flood risk vulnerability and flood zone 'incompatibility'

	Essential Infrastructure	Highly Vulnerable	More Vulnerable	Less Vulnerable	Water Compatible
Flood Zone 1	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Flood Zone 2	✓	**Exception Test required	✓	✓	✓
Flood Zone 3a	**Exception Test required †	X	**Exception Test required	✓	✓
Flood Zone 3b	**Exception Test required *	X	X	X	✓ *

✓ - Exception test not required

**Exception Test Required – See [Section 7](#)

X – Development should not be permitted

"+" In Flood Zone 3a essential infrastructure should be designed and constructed to remain operational and safe in times of flood.

"*" In Flood Zone 3b (functional floodplain) essential infrastructure that has passed the Exception Test, and water-compatible uses, should be designed and constructed to:

- remain operational and safe for users in times of flood;
- result in no net loss of floodplain storage;
- not impede water flows and not increase flood risk elsewhere.

5.3.3. The Sequential Test is a planning tool that local planning authorities apply to ensure that developments in areas at risk of flooding are only approved if the applicant can successfully demonstrate that there are no other reasonably available sites. Decision Makers need to consider whether the test is passed, with reference to the information it holds on land availability. Proposals that cannot pass the Sequential Test should normally be refused and do not proceed to the exception test stage. As such, developers are advised to consider the Sequential Test requirements at the earliest opportunity to avoid unnecessary expense being incurred through progressing an application/ commissioning wider planning surveys and assessments unnecessarily.

5.3.4. [Table 3](#) below goes into more detail than the NPPF and PPG and is intended to provide certainty and consistency to the application of national policy at a local level, taking into account the practical implications of certain types of development and where it may be impractical to suggest there are more suitable sites elsewhere.

5.3.5. A sequential test is not required where development meets the following criteria:

Table 3: When is a Sequential Test Not Required?

Type	Explanation	Exceptions
Development allocated in the Local Plan	Development proposals for sites allocated via Policy 3 and 5 of the Local Plan.	Development on land allocated in the Local Plan, which is for a different/more vulnerable use, will require a Sequential Test. Development on land allocated in the Local Plan where changes have occurred to the understanding of flood risk since Plan adoption. Development on land designated as 'Residential Policy Area', 'Employment Policy Area' or allocated as 'Potential Development Site' will require a Sequential Test.
Minor development ¹	Minor non – residential extensions where they are not in excess of 250m ² .	Any proposed development which creates a separate dwelling within

¹ See NPPF para. 168 and footnote 56

Type	Explanation	Exceptions
	Alterations which do not increase the size of buildings. Householder development (i.e. sheds, garages, games room) within the curtilage of an existing dwelling in addition to any physical extensions to the existing dwelling itself.	the curtilage of another (i.e. subdivision of housing into flats).
Changes of Use	Changes of use which do not involve operational development, or when there is only minor operational development which would not create additional living space or operational floor space. For example where a change of use involves only a new external staircase or shop-front will not require a Sequential Test.	Changes of use which require other operational development; changes of use to a caravan, camping or chalet site, or to a mobile home or park home site (as per NPPF ²).
Subdivision of dwellings	Subdivision of dwellings are excluded from the definition of 'minor development', but are viewed as a change of use application and thus would not require a Sequential Test.	Where subdivision of dwellings result in significant alterations or extensions and / or where these result in ground floor or basement level self – contained rooms.
Replacement dwellings	Replacement dwellings where there is no increase in the number of dwellings or a significant increase in the footprint of the building.	Where there is an increase in the number of dwellings or the footprint of the building has significantly increased. Whether there is a significant increase will be compared to the potential size of the building if available permitted development rights were to be used.
Redevelopment of existing industrial, leisure and commercial (including retail) sites for similar uses	Redevelopment of sites from and to these uses (including any increase in net floorspace) provided they show significant improvements to flood resilience and the new layout maximises the use of lower risk areas of the site.	Where no improvements to flood resilience demonstrated, or does not utilise any lower risk area(s) of the site adequately.
Extensions to existing industrial, leisure and commercial (including retail) sites for similar uses	Extensions up to 250m ² will not require a Sequential Test. In accordance with NPPF.	Extensions over 250m ² unless they are demonstrably proven to be operationally linked to the existing development and will incorporate adequate flood risk mitigation Proposals to intensify sites or units to allow separate uses within an existing site.
Winning and Working of Minerals	Proposals for sand and gravel working are defined in the NPPF as "water compatible development" and do not	Applications that improve flood storage capacity and enhance

² See NPPF Annex 3: Flood risk vulnerability classification

Type	Explanation	Exceptions
	require a Sequential Test. The logic is these can only be worked where they are found. Other mineral resources such as industrial and aggregate limestone will not require a Sequential Test providing the site-specific flood risk assessment shows no increase in flood risk and that surface water will be managed³.	biodiversity will be looked on favourably.
Other minerals and waste development	Other minerals and waste development which is more akin to industrial development will be treated as such. Where the proposal for permanent structure(s) needs locating within a quarry or landfill for operational reasons (such as landfill gas extraction plant) a Sequential Test will be required.	Where a Sequential Test is required, the area of search may be reduced to the boundary of the site.
Developments only partially in Flood Zones	A Sequential Test will not be required where only a small part of the site lies within Flood Zone 2 or 3 and will not be used for hard development (e.g. only used for soft landscaping). The layout of the development should be informed by a site specific flood risk assessment and should also minimise flood risk.	A Sequential Test will be required, even if a small part of the site is in flood risk, if this area includes built development or hard landscaping.

5.3.6. [Table 3](#) goes into more detail than the NPPF and PPG and is intended to provide certainty and consistency to the application of national policy at a local level, taking into account the practical implications of certain types of development and where it may be impractical to suggest there are more suitable sites elsewhere.

6. Undertaking a Sequential Test

6.1. When is a Sequential Test Required?

- 6.1.1. When development falls outside of the parameters in sections [5.2](#) and [5.3](#), a Sequential Test will be required. The aim of the sequential test is to steer new development to areas with the lowest risk of flooding from any source. Development should not be permitted if there are reasonably available sites appropriate for the proposed development in areas with a lower risk of flooding.
- 6.1.2. Policy 57 of the Local Plan and supporting paragraph 14.8 explains the approach to undertaking a Sequential Test. Development is required to identify if there are any alternative sites for the development type proposed, which are reasonably available, within the specified areas of search stipulated in Policy 57 part c as the starting point – unless a smaller area of search can be justified for specific locational reasons such as the development needs to serve a defined catchment.

³ See NPPF Annex 3: Flood risk vulnerability classification

6.1.3. The different types of development, their Sequential Test area of search and what potential sources of information can inform a Sequential Test are as follows:

Table 4: Potential Sources of Information for a Sequential Test

Land Use	Site Size Thresholds	Area of Search (Policy 57)	Council Evidence Base Documents	Notes
Housing	Less than 5 dwellings / 0.1 hectares	Elsewhere in the same settlement	N/A – see 'Notes' column	Small sites are too small for the Council's main evidence base as national planning guidance only applies to 5+ units. Instead, applicants should undertake a review of the housing market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Right Move , Zoopla , On The Market , Plot Finder etc.). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Housing	5 dwellings or more / 0.1 hectares or more	Elsewhere in the same settlement	Doncaster Housing & Economic Land Availability Assessment Residential Land Availability Report 5-Year Housing Land Supply Statement	Applicants should also undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Right Move , Zoopla , On The Market , Plot Finder etc.). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Employment	Less than 0.25 hectares	Elsewhere in the same settlement	N/A – see 'Notes' column	Small sites are too small for the Council's main evidence base as national planning guidance only applies to sites of 0.25 hectares. Instead, applicants should undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc.). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being

Land Use	Site Size Thresholds	Area of Search (Policy 57)	Council Evidence Base Documents	Notes
				marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Employment	0.25 hectares or more	Elsewhere in the same settlement	Doncaster Housing & Economic Land Availability Assessment Employment Land Availability Report	The applicant should undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Offices	N/A	Elsewhere in the Town Centre where the development is being proposed	Doncaster Housing & Economic Land Availability Assessment Employment Land Availability Report	Applicants should also undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Retail	N/A	Elsewhere within the settlements town / district / local centre, <u>or</u> where a settlement does not have a defined retail area, then elsewhere within the same settlement.	n/a see Local Plan Policies Map for boundaries.	Applicants should also undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc.). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
Mixed Use	N/A	Need to justify why the scheme should be viewed as a single proposal, or otherwise separate out the individual	Doncaster Housing & Economic Land Availability Assessment	Applicants should also undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc). The Council notes that

Land Use	Site Size Thresholds	Area of Search (Policy 57)	Council Evidence Base Documents	Notes
		components and assess as above.	Residential Land Availability Report 5-Year Housing Land Supply Statement Employment Land Availability Report	these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.
All other proposals	N/A	Borough wide area of search unless a case can be made to narrow the search area due to certain locational needs of the development or specific catchment requirements		Applicants should also undertake a review of the market and provide evidence from at least 2 online sources (e.g. Zoopla , Business Doncaster Property Search etc.). The Council notes that these sites may include the same land being marketed. If no land/sites/plots are identified then the search should conclude by saying this and evidence the 'nil' return.

6.2. Identifying Reasonably Available Sites

- 6.2.1. Applicants will be expected to identify whether there are any other 'reasonably available' sites within the specified area of search for the type of development that they are proposing. The applicant may also need to check the current status of relevant sites to determine if they can be considered 'reasonably available'.
- 6.2.2. The PPG describes a 'reasonably available site' as one in a suitable location for the type of development with a reasonable prospect that the site is available to be developed at the point in time envisaged for the development. As part of the planning application, the Council will need to see evidence of the area of search used to identify alternate sites, the alternate sites identified within the area of search, and provide an assessment and explanation of whether alternate sites are at a lower flood risk and reasonably available.
- 6.2.3. If the outcome of the Sequential Test is that it is not possible for the development to be located in an area at lower risk of flooding within the specified area of search, then it may be necessary for the Exception Test to be applied (see [Section 7](#)).
- 6.2.4. Conversely, if any reasonably available alternative sites are available within the area of search, the application will be contrary to local and national policy and should normally be recommended for refusal.
- 6.2.5. It is the decision maker's judgement (the Planning Case Officer) as to whether the Sequential Test has been passed, but it is the applicant's responsibility to make sure sufficiently detailed information and evidence has been submitted to allow the Case Officer to easily check and come to the same conclusion as to whether the requirements of the Test have been met.

7. Undertaking an Exception Test

7.1. When is an Exception Test Required?

- 7.1.1. The Exception Test should only be applied when, following the application of the Sequential Test, it has been demonstrated that it is not possible for development to be located in an area at lower risk of flooding.
- 7.1.2. The Exception Test is not a tool to justify development in flood risk areas when the Sequential test has already shown that there are reasonably available, lower risk sites, appropriate for the proposed development. The potential for a development to pass the Exception Test does not remove the requirement to pass the Sequential Test.
- 7.1.3. The Exception Test is a means of demonstrating that flood risk to people and property will be managed satisfactorily, whilst allowing necessary development to go ahead in situations where suitable sites at lower risk of flooding are not available.
- 7.1.4. There are two parts to the Exception Test which requires demonstration that:
 - A. development that has to be in a flood risk area will provide wider sustainability benefits to the community which outweigh flood risk; and

- B.** the development will be safe for its lifetime, taking into account the vulnerability of its users without increasing flood risk elsewhere and, where possible, reduce flood risk overall.

- 7.1.5. The applicant will need to provide the local planning authority with evidence to demonstrate how both elements of the Exception Test will be satisfied and both elements of the Exception Test must be satisfied for the development to be approved.
- 7.1.6. Logically, developers may wish to start with Part B (demonstrating safety and not increasing flood risk elsewhere), because if Part B cannot be proven there is little point addressing Part A, which would in any event rely on information provided by Part B.

7.2. Demonstrating the Sustainability Benefits of a Proposal

- 7.2.1. By its very nature, the planning system must bring forward sustainable development in line with national planning policy's three overarching objectives (economic, social and environmental) which are interdependent and need to be pursued in mutually supportive ways. PPG is clear that it is for Councils to set their own criteria for this assessment having regard to objectives in the Local Plan's Sustainability Appraisal (SA) framework.
- 7.2.2. The SA process for the Local Plan identified a Framework for assessing the likely significant effects of the Plan based on 14 sustainability objectives (several also containing a number of sub-objectives) and a number of guide questions for how the objective will be achieved. In order to assess the likely significant effects of potential development sites on these objectives a number of site selection criteria were identified which were used to appraise the sustainability of site options using a matrix of symbols commonly found through the SA process (++/+/0/?/-/-).
- 7.2.3. Symbols should not be weighted nor should numerical 'scores' be assigned. Instead a RAG (Red-Amber-Green) rating has been used which provides a visual overview of how a development proposal may perform across the range of SA criteria by using a 'traffic light' approach of showing positive effects as green (dark & light shading), neutral effects as amber, and negative effects as red (dark & light shading). Where the effects are uncertain then a '?' should be used (coloured blue).
- 7.2.4. In line with PPG therefore, a blank copy of the Local Plan's SA framework is made available in the [Appendix](#) for applicants to populate and ensure sufficient evidence is available to meet the first part of the Exception Test. As with most supporting information required in support of planning applications, the Council expects the evidence to be proportional to the proposed development. For example, we would expect significantly more detail for a major residential development compared to that expected for an infill dwelling. The approach follows the tried and tested SA methodology of predicating possible effects and we would expect the majority of criteria, if relevant to the proposal, to demonstrate mostly positive (+) or significantly positive (++) effects in order to be able to say that the wider sustainability benefits have been demonstrated that outweighs residual risks.
- 7.2.5. National planning policy and guidance is clear that where wider sustainability benefits are absent, or where they are outweighed by flood risk, the Exception Test has not been satisfied and planning permission should be refused. This is a high bar and highlights the importance of undertaking a robust and proportional SA of the proposal to ensure the wider sustainability benefits are transparent and clear for all to see. It is the decision-makers judgement (the Planning Case Officer) as to whether the first part of the Exception Test has been passed.

7.3. Demonstrating Development Safety and Flooding Impacts, including Residual Flood Risk Zone Planning Advice

- 7.3.1. PPG suggests that incorporating Green Infrastructure, making use of Sustainable Drainage Systems, and/or contributions to flood risk management infrastructure, will help reduce flood risk both on the site and wider area.
- 7.3.2. Policy 57 Part D of the Local Plan also requires proposals in residual flood risk areas to consider the development management advice for these areas as set out in the [SFRA](#) (2015) which provides further information (see section 6.4.1 of the SFRA) around expectations, such as finished floor levels, to assist with identifying sources of flood risk to a proposed development, and helping to ensure that proposals can be mitigated and designed to be safe for their lifetime. All sources of flooding should be considered in the Site Specific Flood Risk Assessment (for further guidance see Section 7.3 of the Council's [Technical and Developer Requirements SPD](#)). In some parts of the Borough, the required mitigation to manage residual flood risk can sometimes result in extremely difficult to overcome technical challenges for planning applications. For example, finished floor levels when an applicant has not expected flood depths of nearly 2 metres in some scenarios/locations where existing site levels are relatively low can lead to issues around development viability given the amount of land raising that's required. Even where viability can be overcome, such solutions can result in wider 'Planning' development management issues, such as design with new development sitting considerably higher above surrounding and existing properties.
- 7.3.3. The Council will ensure its evidence base and planning advice on flood risk, including these residual flood risk areas, is kept up-to-date as and when new modelling and understanding of residual risk changes from all sources, now and in the future, taking account of the impacts of climate change, and to assess the cumulative impact that land use changes and development in the area will have on flood risk.
- 7.3.4. It should, however, be noted that just because a development passes the Sequential and Exception Tests it could still be inappropriate based on other national and local policies.
- 7.3.5. Should the Exception Test be satisfactorily passed, or if the Exception Test was not required, then applicants can proceed to consider site design and applying a site-specific sequential approach to site layout and design.

8. Applying a Site-Specific Sequential Approach to Layout and Design

8.1. How to Apply a Sequential Approach to Site Layout

- 8.1.1. If the Sequential and Exception Tests show that development can be located in an area of flood risk, applicants must follow a sequential approach to flood risk within the site.
- 8.1.2. This means that when designing a site's layout, the most vulnerable uses, such as housing, should be directed to the areas of the site where flood risk is lowest, with water compatible uses, such as open spaces, or other less vulnerable uses being directed to higher risk areas of the site unless there are very clear and justified wider Planning reasons for not being able to do so.

- 8.1.3. This should consider flood risk from all sources. Where possible, the most vulnerable elements of development, such as housing, should be placed on upper floors (i.e. above a garage etc.) to increase safety. Site design must include suitable and safe routes for access and egress.

9. Undertaking a Site Specific Flood Risk Assessment

9.1. Preparing a Site Specific Flood Risk Assessment

- 9.1.1. NPPF footnote 55 states that site specific flood risk assessments should be undertaken for:
- Development in Flood Zone 1 which is:
 - over 1ha in size; or
 - on land identified by the Environment Agency as having critical drainage problems; or
 - on land identified in the SFRA as being at increased risk of flooding in future; or
 - on land that may be subject to other sources of flooding where its development would introduce a more vulnerable use.
 - Any development in Flood Zone 2;
 - Any development in Flood Zone 3.
- 9.1.2. Detailed information on how to undertake a Site Specific Flood Risk Assessment, including a checklist with what information should be included, is provided in [PPG for flood risk and coastal change](#). This also includes advice for minor extensions, standing advice for vulnerable developments and submission of planning applications to the local planning authority, applicants should refer to this in the first instance. Also, please refer to Section 7 of the Council's [Technical and Developer Requirements SPD](#) which advises on Drainage and Flood Risk Management policies and procedures.
- 9.1.3. Site specific flood risk assessments should be proportionate to the degree of flood risk and the scale, nature and location of the proposed development.
- 9.1.4. One of the considerations to ensure that any new development is safe, including where there is a residual risk of flooding from artificial sources for flood risk management infrastructure, is whether adequate flood warning would be available to people using the development. Flood Risk Assessments should be provided for sites vulnerable to flooding from any failure of embankments or supporting structures associated with artificial watercourses, including canals and reservoirs meeting the aims of NPPF (para 167 (part d)). The [Environment Agency Hazard Mapping](#), which covers a wide area of Doncaster, can assist with this, and where it is not available applicants are encouraged to carry out their own breach assessments.
- 9.1.5. An Emergency Plan will be needed wherever emergency flood response is an important component of making a development safe. Emergency Plans will be essential for sites at risk of flooding used to holiday or short-let caravans and camping and for any site with transient occupancy (e.g. hostels and hotels).
- 9.1.6. The applicant is also encouraged to develop an Emergency Plan to include warning and informing, number of people potentially at risk, practicality of safe evacuation from the area and the adequacy of both evacuation routes and identified places that people from evacuated places use/are taken to.

APPENDIX: Local Plan Sustainability Appraisal for Demonstrating Wider Sustainability Benefits that Outweigh Residual Flood Risk to the Development (Exception Test Part A)

The following provides the Local Plan's Red-Amber-Green Sustainability Appraisal Methodology for predicting possible effects from the proposed development (see [Section 7](#)). Please note, in line with national planning policy the Council expects the majority of proposals that will need to undertake this part of the Exception Test as being 'more vulnerable' residential uses. However, it should be noted that other proposals in the 'more vulnerable' classification, and those in 'highly vulnerable' and 'essential infrastructure' classifications will also need to complete the Exception Test. Certain SA criteria may not apply to certain proposals (i.e. the need for older peoples accommodation to be close to a primary school), therefore applicants are invited to scope out these criteria from the appraisal.

To assist applicants, a separate MS Word version of this Appendix has been published alongside the SPD to allow ease of completing the table.

++	Significant positive effects – The proposal will have a significant positive effect on the SA objective when compared to the current and future baseline conditions.
+	Positive effects – The proposal will have a positive effect on the SA objective when compared to the current and future baseline conditions. Minor adverse effects may result but the overall effect will be positive.
0	Neutral – Proposal is unlikely to create any significant effects (positive or negative) at present or in the future.
?	Unknown/ uncertain – There is insufficient information about the implications of the proposal to make a robust assessment.
-	Negative effects – The proposal will have a negative effect on the SA objective being assessed when compared to the current and future baseline conditions. Minor positive effects may result but the overall effect will be negative.
--	Significant negative effects – the proposal will have major negative effects on the SA objective compared to the current and future baseline conditions.

Site Name:	
Site Size (ha)/Capacity (units):	
Brownfield/ Greenfield/ Mixed:	
Brief site description/ existing use:	

Ref	Objective	Sub-Objective	Detailed Decision Making Criteria	Score	Commentary
1	Maintain and increase Doncaster's growth and prosperity and diversify its economic base	A) Local economy (maintain and strengthen)	- Create jobs and new businesses - Support existing businesses - Provide employment opportunities for everyone - Increase wealth - Attract investment and trade - Close the 'output gap' - Improve financial security - Provide a supply of available land for all business needs - Promote tourism - Support home working / e-commerce - Improve quality of life		
		B) Diversify the economic base	- Provide a skilled workforce. - Broaden sectoral mix - Less reliance on current high volume sectors - More workers in 'higher value' sectors - Promote rural diversification		
2	Reinforce and support community identity and pride	A) Support community identity	- Maintain and protect the physical identity and setting of existing settlements - Conserve and protect existing services and facilities (especially in more remote areas) - Deliver affordable homes - Promote greater community cohesion - Don't make everywhere the same		
		B) Pride	- Get people involved in local issues. - Foster positive perceptions of the area - Make people proud of their own community and Doncaster		

Ref	Objective	Sub-Objective	Detailed Decision Making Criteria	Score	Commentary
3	Improve accessibility to places and services, both within and outside of the borough	A) Accessibility to places	▪ Ensure places can be accessed via public transport ▪ Encourage a modal shift ▪ Minimise travel to work distance ▪ Has footpath access where possible ▪ Has cycle paths where possible ▪ Have adequate parking facilities ▪ Has road access where possible ▪ Facilitate links between urban and rural areas		
		B) Accessibility to services	▪ Facilitate access to services and facilities such as health, education, open spaces and shops etc. ▪ New development should be close to services ▪ Facilitate the transport of freight by sustainable means ▪ Minimise the need to travel		
4	Ensure resources are available and efficiently used to sustain development and reduce waste and consumption	A) Energy resources	▪ Reduce the reliance on, and the consumption of, finite fossil fuels ▪ Reduce greenhouse gas emissions ▪ Reduce energy use and encourage the production and use of renewable energy		
		B) Minerals and construction	▪ Reduce primary mineral extraction ▪ Increase the use of recycled and reclaimed aggregates ▪ Incorporate sustainable design and construction practices		
		C) Efficient use of waste	▪ Encourage reuse/recycling and minimise waste		
5	Provide affordable, good quality housing that is available to everyone, including vulnerable and disadvantaged groups	A) Affordability	▪ Provide housing including affordable housing that is available to everyone to address future needs		
		B) Quality	▪ Promote and encourage good quality design and sustainable homes		
		C) Mix and range of homes	▪ Ensure an appropriate mix of housing, tenures and types		
		D) Availability	▪ Increase the supply of housing ▪ Address areas of market failure		

Ref	Objective	Sub-Objective	Detailed Decision Making Criteria	Score	Commentary
6	Reduce social exclusion and disadvantage	A) Social exclusion	- Minimise disadvantage or discrimination - Ensure that as many people as possible have good access to shops and services		
		B) Social disadvantage	- Reduce concentrations of socio- economic disadvantage - Reduce the gap between affluent and deprived areas		
7	Make places that are safe, attractive, culturally interesting and distinctive to live, work and travel in	A) Attractive and distinctive places	- Deliver a high quality built environment - Promote local distinctiveness - Provide more greenspaces and trees - Maintain and improve the character and setting of the townscape and landscape		
		B) Safety and security	- Promote buildings and developments which are 'secure by design' - Address anti-social behaviour - Maximise the security of homes and workplaces - Reduce crime - Reduce fear of crime - Minimise risk to health and safety		
8	Renew and reuse existing buildings, land and infrastructure	A) Land and buildings	- Encourage the re-use of brownfield land, vacant sites and existing buildings - Avoid the unnecessary use of greenfield sites - Support renewal of old and/or poor areas of housing - Protect and enhance the amenity of the area - Secure the removal of unstable and contaminated land		
		B) Infrastructure	- Capacity of existing infrastructure to support new development - Quality of existing infrastructure provision		
9	Improve the health and well-being of the borough's population	A) Health	- Address health inequalities - Make it easier for people to pursue a healthy lifestyle - Promote access to healthcare - Reduce the fear of crime and anti-social behaviour		

Ref	Objective	Sub-Objective	Detailed Decision Making Criteria	Score	Commentary
		B) Well-being	▪ Increase personal satisfaction ▪ Improve quality of life ▪ Enhance people's ability to access opportunities ▪ Encourage community participation		
10	Provide education and training provision to build the skills and capacity of the population	A) Education	▪ Improve educational attainment ▪ Provide more/sufficient school places to address future need		
		B) Skills and training	▪ Improve qualifications and skills in young people ▪ Provide opportunities for adults to learn new skills		
11	Manage and adapt to climate change	A) Flood risk	▪ Avoid inappropriate development in flood risk areas ▪ Manage flood risk on sites at risk of flooding		
		B) Greenhouse gas emissions	▪ Reduce greenhouse gas emissions ▪ Improve/increase Doncaster's resilience to climate change ▪ Support the delivery of renewable and low carbon energy and associated infrastructure ▪ Secure energy efficiency improvements		
		C) Water supply and drainage	▪ Encourage sustainable drainage practices ▪ Manage and protect our water supply		
12	Protect, increase and enhance the natural environment, including the landscape, its underlying geology and wildlife habitat	A) Biodiversity (habitats and species)	▪ Protect, maintain and improve sites of international, national and local importance. ▪ Create new areas of biodiversity value ▪ Offset / compensate for the loss of habitats and species as a result of development ▪ Protect and restore priority species and habitats		
		B) Geodiversity	▪ Protect, maintain and improve sites of geodiversity importance		
		C) Landscape	▪ Maintain and enhancing landscape quality and character		

Ref	Objective	Sub-Objective	Detailed Decision Making Criteria	Score	Commentary
13	Protect, conserve and enhance the historic and cultural heritage	A) Historic places	- Protect, maintain and improve the character and appearance of conservation areas - Maintain and protect historic buildings, scheduled ancient monuments and their settings - Protect, maintain and improve national and local historic parks and gardens - Protect, maintain and enhance archaeological assets		
		B) Cultural Heritage	- Promote and increase tourism - Sensitive management of historic townscape - Protect undesignated archaeological assets from damage or loss		
14	Protect and enhance soil, air and water quality (watercourses and ground water)	A) Land and soil	- Avoid the sterilisation of minerals - Restore, reclaim and remediate vacant and derelict land (e.g. contaminated sites) - Encourage local food production		
			Will the site impact on best and most versatile agricultural land?		
		B) Water	- Increase the quality and quantity of the water environment - Reduce direct and indirect pollution on the water environment - Reduce the potential risk to ecosystems (e.g. wetland and riparian habitats) and ecological receptors		
		C) Air	- Reduce/minimise air pollution (e.g. increased traffic) and noise - Improve air quality especially at motorway junctions and busy A roads - Reduce the potential risk to ecosystems (e.g. wetland and riparian habitats) and ecological receptors		

